

SHIFTS IN FOCUS

Moving attention from one thing to another



1 What is it?

Shifts In Focus

A shift in focus is when a writer **deliberately moves attention** from one character, detail, or idea to another — a zoom-in, a zoom-out, or a change in what the reader is looking at.

focus A → focus B

2 See it in action

Zooming in

A description moves from a whole battlefield down to one soldier's shaking hands.

Zooming out

A story pulls back from one bedroom to the whole silent city outside.

Character to character

The narrative shifts from the hero's thoughts to the villain's in the next paragraph.

Detail to theme

A description of a cracked teacup shifts focus onto the family's fractured relationships.



Keep going!

Picture the text like a **camera** — is it zooming in on a small detail, or pulling back to show the bigger picture? That visual metaphor makes shifts easy to spot.

FUN FACT

Film directors and novelists use exactly the same trick — a camera zooming from a wide shot to a close-up on someone's face is the visual version of a structural shift in focus.

3 Why writers use it

Shifts In Focus help writers: control what the reader notices and when, create contrast between the small/personal and the big/universal, and connect a specific detail to a wider theme.

Shifting focus is one of the clearest ways a writer directs a reader's attention like a camera — deciding exactly what to show, and in what order.

4 Don't mix it up!

Shifts in Focus

- Moves attention **within a scene**
- A zoom in/out or character change
- Same time and place

Changes in Perspective

- Changes **who is telling** the story
- A shift in narrative viewpoint
- Can span different times/places



Watch out!

A shift in focus is about **WHAT** the reader is looking at — don't confuse it with a change in perspective, which is about **WHO** is telling the story.



Mfalme says...

Always ask **why** the writer chose to shift focus exactly there — what does the new focus reveal that the old one couldn't?

5 Quick recap

Moves attention from one thing to another

A zoom in or zoom out

Directs what the reader notices



Look here!

Try writing one paragraph that starts zoomed in on a tiny detail (a single raindrop) and ends zoomed out on a whole city skyline.